

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Signal the close -> Give a warm and honest reason -> End clean

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Signal your exit before you actually leave. Give one brief, honest reason. End the conversation cleanly rather than trailing off.

BEST FOR

- Ending networking conversations without awkwardness
- Leaving a social event or meeting gracefully
- Getting off a long phone call cleanly
- Any conversation you need to end without damaging the relationship

PHRASE BANK

Exit Signals · Signalling you are wrapping up

- "I want to wrap up shortly —"
- "Before I go —"
- "I have to be somewhere in a few minutes, but —"
- "One last thing before I head off —"
- "I am going to let you go, but —"
- "I need to move on shortly —"
- "I want to close this conversation well —"

Warm Exit Phrases · Leaving well

- "This was a really useful conversation — thank you."
- "I want to come back to this — can we set a time?"
- "I am glad we had the chance to talk."
- "I want to think about what you said — I will follow up."
- "Thanks for making time for this."
- "I will leave it there — but I am glad we talked."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Trailing off and slowly backing away
Better: I should probably get going.
Best: I need to head off in a moment — but I wanted to say it was good to connect.
2. Weak: Abrupt exit: 'Sorry I have to go, bye'
Better: I have to go — thanks for chatting.
Best: Signal -> brief warm close -> clean end. Thirty seconds total.
3. Weak: Fake reason to leave
Better: I have something I need to get to.
Best: Honest reason, briefly stated. Or simply: 'I am going to head off.'

DECISION TREE

If Conversation is going on too long and you need to leave

Signal the exit before leaving. Give one honest, brief reason.

"I need to be somewhere in a few minutes — let me finish this thought first."

If The other person does not notice you are trying to leave

Name it more directly.

"I am going to have to head off now."

If You are leaving a conversation that was difficult

Close with something genuine before leaving.

"I want to leave this in a decent place — thanks for talking it through."

If You trail off rather than making a clean exit

End with a definite statement, not a trailing sentence.

"On that note — I am going to go. Good to see you."

SCENARIOS

Networking event: conversation with no natural end point

Signal the close. Reference something they said. Leave warmly. — "I want to keep moving — but that point you made about X was worth the conversation."

Long phone call that has already reached its natural end

Name the close before trailing off. — "I want to let you go — but before I do: ..."

Dinner or social event: leaving before others

Brief goodbye to each person. Do not sneak out. — "I am going to head off — thanks for a great evening."

Meeting that has overrun by thirty minutes

Signal the exit with enough time for a clean close. — "I have a hard stop in five minutes — can we make sure we close on the next steps?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the other person is in distress and leaving would feel like abandonment.
- When there is unfinished critical business that genuinely needs resolution before the conversation closes.
- When your exit will be read as avoidance of something difficult.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice your exits

In your next three conversations, notice how you ended them. Did you trail off? Make a clean exit? Leave awkwardly?

Day 2 — Signal before leaving

In one conversation, say out loud that you are about to leave before you actually do.

Day 3 — The warm close

End one conversation with a genuine, specific warm statement before leaving.

Day 4 — Clean ending sentence

Practise ending on a definite sentence rather than trailing off.

Day 5 — The thirty-second exit

In one conversation, complete the full exit in thirty seconds: signal, warm close, done.

Day 6 — Difficult exits

End one conversation that has been tense or difficult with a genuine close.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did exits feel clean? Did people seem satisfied rather than cut off? Did any exit feel too abrupt or too long?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I signal I was leaving before actually leaving?
- Did I give a brief, honest reason?
- Did I end with something warm and genuine?

- Did I avoid trailing off or sneaking out?
- Did the exit feel appropriately brief — not a new conversation?
- Did the other person seem to feel properly closed off?
- Did I keep the close to under a minute?